THE LAST CAMPAIGN

On a cold November night in 1598, Padshah Akbar mounted an elephant and left the city of Lahore, never to return. In the icy darkness, the Padshah had much to ruminate over. All his sons were refusing to obey his orders, though always obliquely, so it was hard to gauge where suspicion ended and presumption began. In the Deccan, it was difficult to pin Murad down, or get him to return to court. Daniyal had left his post at Allahabad and Salim was staunchly resisting his mission to march to Turan and reclaim their 'ancestral'* dominions, no doubt wary of distancing himself from a court in which the situation was so volatile with the other princes. So Akbar had decided to go to the Deccan himself, unnerved by persistent rumours of dissension and disobedience within the Mughal forces led by Murad.

Akbar crossed the Sutlej by elephant before proceeding by boat to Delhi, to visit the tomb of his father, Humayun. When he finally arrived at Agra, thirteen years after he had left the region with such haste following the death of Birbal, he decided to halt in the city and consider the weight of his sons' transgressions.

Abu'l Fazl had been sent from Agra with instructions to bring Murad back to court. But Murad was mortally ill, in body and mind. His beloved son, Rustam, had died a few months previously in Lahore, while in the care of his grandparents. That the boy, nine years old at the time, was a great favourite of the royal harem, and the Padshah, can be guessed at by the enormous grief of his family, as described by Abu'l Fazl. The child, according to him, was exceptionally gentle and sensitive and 'any excess of anger made him ill'. Though Rustam was brought up in the care of Akbar and Hamida Banu, it would appear that Murad, quite understandably, was devastated by the death of his son. Salim wrote in his memoir of a garden, the Rustam Bari, that Murad named in memory of his son near Ahmadnagar. The death of his son, in addition to his failure in successfully taking Ahmadnagar, and thereby disappointing his father, seemed to destroy Murad. This prince, of whom so much had been expected, and who seemed to possess innate talents since, according to Abu'l Fazl, 'he had an open heart, and a liberal hand, and had courage along with gravity' was brought